him if Berlin question brought to a head before or after our Congressional elections. He did not want to make things more difficult for President—and in fact would like to help him." The same message was delivered to Robert Kennedy through the Soviet intelligence officer Georgii Bolshakov, with an additional request: Khrushchev wanted Kennedy to stop American overflights of Soviet ships on their way to Cuba. President Kennedy met with Bolshakov in the White House on July 30 and expressed interest in the deal. At that time, as far as Kennedy was concerned, Cuba barely existed on the Soviet-American agenda, which was fully dominated by Berlin.[9]

Unbeknownst to Kennedy, Khrushchev was playing his Berlin card to distract the president's attention from Cuba. For him, the construction of the Berlin Wall had resolved the crisis, and he did not want to reopen it any time soon. He wrote to the East German leader, Walter Ulbricht, on September 28, a few weeks before the Checkpoint Charlie confrontation between Soviet and American tanks: "Under the present circumstances, since the measures for the safeguarding and control of the GDR borders with West Berlin have been implemented successfully, since the Western powers are tending towards negotiations and contacts between the USSR and the US have already been made in New York, such steps which could exacerbate the situation, especially in Berlin, should be avoided."[10]

The Soviet leader did his best to persuade Ulbricht to abandon the idea of a separate peace treaty with the USSR. "What is pushing us to a peace treaty?" he asked the dissatisfied Ulbricht in February 1962 and responded on his own behalf: "Nothing. Until August 13 [the day the Berlin Wall went up], we were racking our brains over how to move forward. Now the borders are closed." In June 1962, addressing a Czechoslovak delegation, Khrushchev ridiculed both Ulbricht and the idea of a separate treaty. "The signing of a treaty," argued Khrushchev, "might lead to an economic blockade of the GDR in the first instance. Then Comrade Ulbricht would be the first to come and ask us for gold.… The Germans fought a war with us, but now they have a higher standard of living than we do, yet we are supposed to keep giving and giving."[11]

Although Khrushchev did not plan to escalate the Berlin crisis, he was also reluctant to take it off the international agenda. For him it had become a bargaining chip and tool of blackmail too valuable to discard. Khrushchev